A DIFFERENT DAWN

Long ignored as a disability, autism finally gets the attention and empathy it deserves, and benefits from new research, improved diagnosis and a growing neurodiversity movement

By Sonali Acharjee



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Rakesh B.S., 36, from Thiruvananthapuram, was 34 when his wife scheduled a therapy intervention for his situational mutism—an anxiety-driven fear of social interaction, where he found it difficult to speak on select occasions. It was then that he discovered that there was a reason why he behaved in a way that he couldn't understand or control. He had lived with the symptoms for the past three decades and endured for years the label of a "weird kid". His speech was mostly normal, so no one suspected anything more. Till his wife read up on his condition and decided he needed help. "My wife helped me unmask my innate needs, which helped the therapist see that I was autistic," says Rakesh.

Autism—a neurodevelopmental disorder that affects social interaction and communication skills—has long been underdiagnosed and overlooked because it is not one disorder, but a set of symptoms. Also, no two autistic persons need have the same combination of symptoms. The condition, therefore, is diagnosed on a spectrum—hence its formal name, ASD or Autism Spectrum Disorder—denoting the varying presentation of symptoms in each autistic person. Severe autistic individuals may experience seizures, have phases of violence or be unable to speak, while others may have milder, more nuanced symptoms—say, being unsmiling and avoiding eye contact, having an aversion to certain smells or sounds, flapping of hands or stimming (repeating the same movements or sounds), or not mixing with other children.